

Understanding School Leavers' Perceptions of Open and Distance Learning Institutions
A 7Ps Marketing Mix Analysis from Sri Lanka

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The Higher Education Landscape in Sri Lanka

- Higher education institutions operate in increasingly **competitive environments** where effective marketing is essential for attracting prospective students (Kotler & Fox, 1995; Hemsley-Brown & Oplatka, 2006).
- In Sri Lanka, participation in higher education remains **limited**, particularly among rural school leavers facing financial, geographic, and infrastructural barriers (World Bank, 2022; UNESCO, 2023).
- **Open and Distance Learning (ODL)** offers a pathway to widening access through flexible, digitally supported learning.

Research Gap: Despite the widespread use of the 7Ps marketing framework in higher education, little is known about how prospective Sri Lankan school leavers perceive ODL institutions. Misconceptions regarding quality and employability persist.

Study Focus: This study applies the 7Ps marketing framework to examine ODL marketing perceptions among 215 school leavers across five Sri Lankan districts to inform more effective and equitable marketing strategies.

Aims and Hypotheses

Primary Aim: To identify the underlying dimensions of higher education marketing perceptions among Sri Lankan school leavers using the 7Ps framework, and to examine differences across demographic and geographic characteristics

Specific Objectives:

- Identify the underlying dimensions of higher education marketing perceptions using the 7Ps framework.
- Examine perceptual differences across demographic and geographic characteristics.
- Determine the most influential marketing dimensions for prospective ODL learners.

Hypothesis: Perceptions of the ODL marketing mix will vary significantly according to selected demographic and geographic factors among Sri Lankan school leavers.

Theoretical Foundations

ODL as a Widening Participation Strategy

- ODL provides **flexible, digitally supported** learning opportunities for geographically, socially, and economically disadvantaged learners (Camilleri, 2020).
- The **Open University of Sri Lanka (OUSL)** has expanded access through a nationwide network of regional study centres.
- Enrolment remains constrained by perceptions regarding **service quality, learner support, and institutional credibility** (Guri-Rosenblit, 2005; Zawacki-Richter & Anderson, 2014).

The 7Ps Framework in Higher Education

- The **7Ps marketing mix** (Product, Price, Place, Promotion, People, Process, Physical Evidence) is widely used in higher education marketing (Booms & Bitner, 1981; Ivy, 2008).
- Marketing increasingly functions to **communicate value** and reduce barriers to participation.
- Despite its prevalence, **limited research** exists on how prospective Sri Lankan school leavers evaluate ODL institutions through this lens.

> **Key Insight:** Understanding how prospective learners evaluate ODL institutions has become essential for designing effective marketing strategies that build trust and widen participation.

Research Design & Data Collection

Design

Cross-sectional quantitative survey involving **215 school leavers** from five Sri Lankan districts, selected through **systematic random sampling** at OUSL regional centres.

Study Sites

Matale (34.0%), **Kegalla** (20.5%), **Anuradhapura** (17.7%), **Monaragala** (15.3%), and **Badulla** (12.6%).

Instrument

Structured questionnaire in **Sinhala and Tamil** comprising **19 items** representing the 7Ps marketing mix, measured on a **five-point Likert scale**.

Validity & Reliability

Content validity established through expert review (CVI $\geq$ 0.78) and a pilot study ($n = 30$). Analysed in **IBM SPSS v26.0**.

Analytical Methods: Descriptive statistics, Principal Component Analysis (PCA) with Varimax rotation, Cronbach's alpha reliability testing, and one-way ANOVA with Tukey's HSD post hoc tests ($\alpha = 0.05$).

RESULTS — RESPONDENT PROFILE

Sample Characteristics (n = 215)

VARIABLE	CATEGORY	%
District	Matale	34.0
	Kegalla	20.5
	Anuradhapura	17.7
	Monaragala	15.3
	Badulla	12.6
Gender	Female / Male	88.4 / 11.6
Age (years)	18–20	49.3
	21–23	40.5
	24–26	4.7
	>26	5.6
Distance	<5 km	34.4
	6–20 km	38.1
	>20 km	27.4



Note: The majority of respondents are young school leavers (89.8% aged 18–23), representing the core target demographic for ODL widening participation.

Principal Component Analysis (PCA) Findings

Factorability: KMO = 0.789; Bartlett's $\chi^2 = 1768.941$, df = 171, $p < .001$ | Variance Explained: 67.7% | Rotation: Varimax

FACTOR	REPRESENTATIVE ITEMS	LOADING RANGE	CRONBACH'S α
F1 — Physical Environment & Accessibility	Cleanliness, ease of access, facilities	0.79–0.91	0.727
F2 — Staff Support & Service Quality	Academic, management, security staff	0.65–0.77	0.737
F3 — Administrative Process Quality	Exam updates, admissions, counselling	0.63–0.76	0.735
F4 — Payment Flexibility	Flexible plans, payment methods	0.77–0.86	0.828
F5 — Campus Environment & Wayfinding	Infrastructure, signage, landscape	0.63–0.75	0.548*
F6 — Cost Affordability	Tuition fees, programme affordability	0.66–0.83	0.738

Key Finding 1: The traditional Price dimension separated into two distinct factors: Payment Flexibility and Cost Affordability, indicating that payment mechanisms are conceptually distinct from overall educational cost.

Key Finding 2: Product, Promotion, and Place converged into centre-mediated constructs, suggesting that regional study centers shape prospective learners' holistic perceptions of ODL institutions.

**F5 exhibited an alpha coefficient below the recommended threshold (α = .548) but was retained due to acceptable factor loadings, conceptual coherence, and exploratory nature of the study.*

Perceptual Ratings and Demographic Effects

Factor-Level Mean Scores (5-point Likert)



Lowest items: Ease of Access (M = 2.53) and Cleanliness (M = 2.54) — highest variability (SD = 1.25–1.51)

ANOVA Summary — Significant Effects

FACTOR	GENDER	DISTRICT	AGE	DISTANCE
F1 — Physical Environment	ns	p = .004*	p = .041*	p = .041*
F2 — Staff Support	ns	p = .022*	ns	ns
F3 — Admin. Process	ns	ns	ns	ns
F4 — Payment Flexibility	ns	p < .001*	ns	ns
F5 — Campus Environment	ns	ns	ns	ns
F6 — Cost Affordability	ns	ns	ns	ns

Key Insight: District of residence was the strongest predictor of perceptual differences, exceeding the influence of geographic distance. Gender showed no significant effect across any dimension.

Interpretation of Key Findings

Restructured 7Ps Framework

Prospective school leavers organize marketing perceptions into a **six-factor structure** rather than the traditional seven dimensions. The separation of Price into Payment Flexibility and Cost Affordability highlights that payment mechanisms are conceptually distinct from overall educational cost.

Centre-Mediated Perceptions

The convergence of **Product, Promotion, and Place** suggests that regional study centers shape prospective learners' holistic perceptions of ODL institutions. Physical infrastructure remains a critical trust signal despite the digital nature of ODL.

District Over Distance

District differences exceeded the influence of geographic distance, suggesting that **local socioeconomic contexts** shape marketing perceptions more strongly than physical proximity (Taylor & Cantwell, 2019).

Infrastructure Deficits

The low ratings for **Physical Environment and Accessibility** ($M = 2.60$) indicate that tangible institutional cues remain important despite the digital nature of ODL, emphasizing the continuing importance of regional learning infrastructure.

Theoretical Contribution: This study extends the application of the 7Ps marketing framework to ODL by demonstrating that prospective learners in developing-country contexts restructure traditional marketing dimensions around tangible center-based experiences and financial accessibility concerns.

Recommendations for Policy and Practice

Key Conclusions

- Prospective Sri Lankan school leavers evaluate ODL institutions using a **six-factor marketing structure** rather than the traditional 7Ps framework.
- **Payment flexibility**, learner support, and regional study centres are the most salient dimensions.
- **District-responsive** marketing strategies are essential — uniform national campaigns are insufficient.
- **Gender showed no significant effect**, though the female-skewed sample (88.4%) - Male students participation in HE

Policy Recommendations

- Invest in **regional study-centre infrastructure** and improve campus navigation and accessibility.
- Expand **flexible tuition payment schemes** to address the dual concern of affordability and payment convenience.
- Enhance **local learner support services** and staff training at district level.
- Tailor **outreach activities** to the socioeconomic characteristics of individual districts.

Future Research: Future studies should employ more **gender-balanced and nationally representative samples** to confirm the robustness of the identified factor structure and marketing perceptions across Sri Lanka.

SELECTED REFERENCES

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Thank you for your attention.